troops were ordered to let them in and not to intervene. They just stood by. Investigators later reckoned that between 1000 and 2000 people were killed. The rest of the world was horrified. Even in Israel, a crowd of 400,000 protested against the actions of their armed forces. An Israeli government inquiry later blamed Sharon and said he was unfit to be Defence Minister. He was forced to resign although this did not prevent his becoming Prime Minister in 2001.

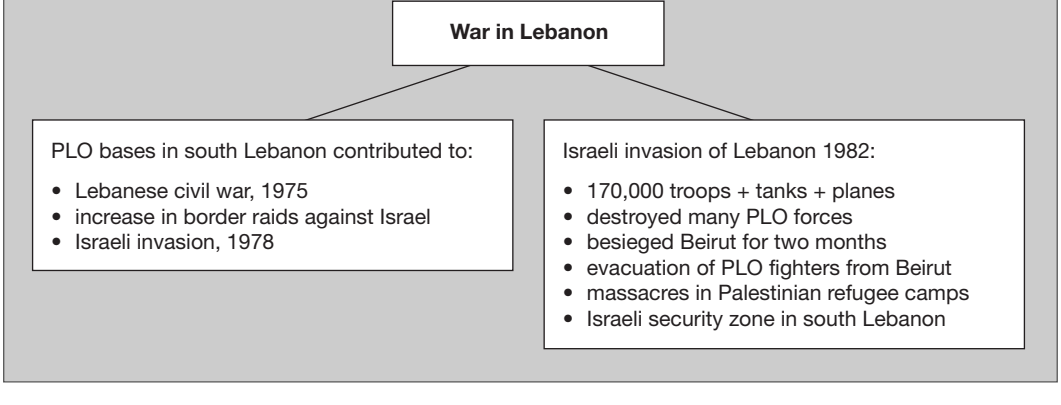
The Israelis withdraw 1985

Key question
What had the Israelis achieved?

After the PLO forces left Beirut, the Israelis withdrew their troops from the capital but they stayed in the south of Lebanon. They had succeeded in driving out the Palestinian armed forces although they could still not be sure that they had driven them *all* out: the guerrillas could easily hide in the huge, crowded refugee camps in southern Lebanon. Worse still, the Israelis had made many enemies amongst the Lebanese, especially the Muslims, in the south. Many of these were to become members of **Hizbollah**, a fiercely anti-Israeli organisation.

Key term
Hizbollah
A radical Islamic group based in southern Lebanon.

The Israeli government faced further problems. International opinion blamed them for thousands of civilian deaths while, in Israel itself, huge numbers demonstrated against the war. They accused the government of turning a defensive war into an aggressive one and of sending hundreds of Israelis, as well as thousands of Palestinians and Lebanese, to their deaths unnecessarily.

Over the next two years, there were regular assaults on Israeli troops in the south of Lebanon. When Israelis heard news of events like Sana M'Heidli's attack on their troops (see page 83), many of them demanded a complete withdrawal from Lebanon. In 1985, Israeli troops withdrew from most of Lebanon, leaving only a small military presence in the 'security zone' along the southern border. This was the longest war Israel had fought. Many regarded it as its first defeat.

Summary diagram: War in Lebanon